

Story1

They were trying to find the beach from the guidebook. He'd bought the guidebook at the train station, some dutiful gesture on his way to the residency, but hadn't even opened it. She hadn't known him then—when he bought the guidebook. Not that she really knew him now. He insisted on using the guidebook to pick this beach, their last beach, like he could still make the purchase worthwhile.

The G.P.S. was on the car's screen, the route marked in green. He missed the turn on the roundabout. She didn't say anything. Another go-around. He made a quick, nervous veer for an exit, her water bottle rolling off the dashboard. Am I going the right way, he said, his voice on the edge of a snap. I know as much as you, she said. She must have sounded annoyed. So this is what it would be like, he said. If this went on. We'd hate each other?

They were going the right way. Or some version of the right way. They drove past the beach they'd gone to before. Only twice in the past ten days, but enough that she thought of it as their usual beach, in the way that even the smallest temporary world takes on its own signposts and traditions.

He had been mostly quiet on those beach days. Reading printed-out articles, taking notes with a pen. His absorption was real. She imagined this is what his family might experience: his young child, his young wife. She nudged closer, took his shirtsleeve between her teeth then let it drop. He smiled in a far-off way. For long stretches he swam in the ocean, leaving her on her towel.

Did you see me jump off the rock? No, she hadn't. Did he notice she had gone in the water, too, that her hair was dripping? No, he hadn't.

Maybe she wanted it to be something other than what it was. She pissed by his parked rental car, squatting in the dry grass, a man walking past with a dog off leash.

They'd brought beers and an opener and towels from the residency to that first beach—the house manager had been angry. Those were bath towels, not to leave the house. There were other towels, specific towels, that residents were allowed to take to the beach. The house manager didn't pretend not to be exasperated with them. The house manager knew everything, knew exactly who was and who was not sleeping in their own bed. The towels were the least of it. People must have acted dumb all the time.

At night, the house manager sat in the hammock by the abandoned tennis court and called her family in Bolivia.

They parked in the lot. There weren't many cars. He wanted to bring the guidebook to the beach. Right? If you want, she said. She didn't say—why would you need the guidebook, exactly? They started to walk along a paved road. It seemed clear, after a while, that it wasn't the way. There was a botanic garden back near the parking lot. The woman at the desk gave them directions

in English. This way, he said with certainty. She followed him. They hit a dead end. I think she meant that first left. He clomped along in his basketball shoes.

The Europeans at the residency had made fun of them. Not unkindly. They shared their cigarettes. You smile a lot, they told him at dinner. The dirt path grew steep and narrow. She picked her way down: she hadn't realized how high up they were, how far the water was, until the cove appeared. He took a photo with his phone. She took a photo of him taking a photo. Then her own photo of the cove. Later, they would both show the cove photos to the people waiting for them at home, the wife and the husband. Or that's what she imagined.

The cove had an apron of concrete instead of a sandbank. The sun lit it up. It wasn't the beach from the guidebook—not even close. Would either of them mention this was the wrong beach? There was a couple in sunglasses sharing a blanket. Farther out, on the rocks, was a group of young people—they had beers, food, the pretty women going bare-breasted. She would have paid them anything for a beer. If she had cash. If— He went swimming. Wearing his long swim trunks. The Europeans said American men dressed like children. The water rolled in with the barest energy, never quite becoming a wave. He swam far across the cove. All the way to the other side. She took her time getting in. Halting steps. The water was cold and clear. She stood up to her shoulders. Come here, he called out to her. She knew she wouldn't swim to him. She dunked her head, anyway, doggy-paddled a bit. She was a bad swimmer. He was happy there, on the other side of the cove. On a rock in the full sun. He didn't need her to join him. He called to her again. Whatever he said, she couldn't make it out.

Already the sun was drifting toward the ridge—it was later than she thought. She moved her towel to stay in the sun. The group on the rocks was having a good time. She didn't understand their Spanish, but she understood that part. They took turns jumping into the water, climbed out dripping. They didn't bother with towels. She almost asked them for a beer. Maybe if she were alone.

When she looked across the cove, she couldn't see him. He'd swum out past the point, she guessed. She had her sunglasses and a book she didn't read. She had barely read anything the past ten days. She had not worked. It seemed like no one else had, either, even the German. She decided to take off her swimsuit top. Her breasts were pale, puckered from the cold water. She spread the top on a rock to dry and waited.

She heard him getting out of the water but didn't open her eyes until he was right there. Oh hi, he said. Her nakedness embarrassed him in an appealing way. He was almost a decade younger than she was. She could see that he had always been a handsome man and that it had probably made his life worse. It made people want things from him. He took a photo of her lying there, an arm covering her breasts. He'd delete it from his phone before he went home—she would remind him.

I miss you, he'd write to her later, back in the States, though the nights she

went to his room he was nervous and spoke to the ceiling and they mostly just talked and he seemed relieved when she crept back to her own room.

Some mornings, the wind knocked over the wicker furniture on the patio and blew tree branches onto the cracked tennis court and everyone stayed indoors, waiting silently for their turn at the Nespresso, and that's when she looked around and thought, Who are these people?

Their trains left the next morning. Different trains. He would give her a ride to the station. They would miss their trains, nearly. He would run a red light, would act nonchalant. The woman at the rental-car drop-off would snap at him. Her anger seemed outsized. Leave the keys in the car, she was saying. Leave the keys—it took them a while to understand. His train would leave first. Already they would be shy with each other. He would walk down the train-station corridor, and she would watch him leave, become a body among other bodies that she did not know.

That was the next day, though. Now, they drove back from the beach with the windows down. Her hair was almost dry. She could play music from her phone, as long as the cell service held out. The old singers. Some country. Some folks' lives roll easy, please let me go round again. Do I still figure in your life. He didn't know a lot of the songs. Did she have that album, he wanted to know, where Bob's voice sounds so sweet? Of course she did. That one song, he said. The song— Yeah. —when Johnny Cash sings, too.

They drove along the fields. There were signs for other towns. The town with the museum, the town with the ceramics—she had seen none of it. A line from an old story she'd read came to her. The ending was sudden, as in certain European movies—that was the line. She couldn't remember anything else about the story. Who had written it. What it had been about. As in certain European movies. As in certain— And that poem someone had written for her once: she'd been twenty, he'd been—what? Much older. Probably her age now, funny to think. Girl from the North Country, because she loved listening to that song. She's only twenty, only twenty, only twenty—that part of the poem had made her laugh. It wasn't supposed to. But he'd probably written it in five minutes, who cared. She'd liked the last line: This is the part where Johnny Cash comes in.

There was service till they got to the mountains. The road winding up into the green trees—that's when the music stopped. This is the part where Johnny Cash comes in, she thought. She looked out the window. This is the part where—

-----The End-----

Story2

Their final beach trip together was eagerly planned amid a dizzying haze of excitement, never-ending laughter, bottled mojitos, and earnest kisses. The sand-colored rental car had driven them to their destination; the cozy blankets

they shared kept them warm at night, and the lifesaving sunscreen preserved their delicate skin. Each of these items appeared as simple tools of inevitability for the culmination of their adventures under the burning summer sun. Heather and Del, bound together by the tender kisses they once shared in the surprising intimacy of their first engaged gaze, now found themselves standing at the edge of the shore, toes pressed into the wet sand, and eyes fixed on the enigmatic horizon.

Heather admired the way the sun taunted them as it sunk below the sea, completely awestruck by the brilliant orange blaze—it reminded her of the sensation she felt when her own body caught fire, ignited by Del’s touch. She was fascinated by the immaculate line that the sun formed against the water. Sharing this little island with Del, Heather noticed how his voice became muffled and distant, lost in the labyrinth of her consciousness. Thinking back on everything that had led them to this point, she began to question reality. The separation of the sun and sea depended only on her perspective, and ever the dreamer, she could choose to watch them merge as one, coexisting within the sphere of her awareness.

Feeling the extended yet gentle silence between them, Del finally asked, “What are you thinking about?”

Heather’s voice exuded warmth like the sun they’d been watching, as she replied softly, “I imagine the sun sinking into the sea, like melting gold flowing into its lover’s embrace.”

Del considered her words while still standing idly with uncertainty and a hint of suspicion. A malicious inner turmoil forced him to confront the gnawing question of whether to maintain his doubts or to give in to that spark of romanticism. Did she mean the sun melting the water and evaporating it, boiling the ocean’s organisms into a state of life-extinction, or drying up the world until it became nothing but black sores of star-dust and cosmic desolation?

Del shifted on his knees and glanced down at his toes, where bits of seafoam playfully tickled the wet hairs. Dismissing his skepticism, he stifled his anxieties and decided to accept it as a poetic image. Putting on a brave smile, he said, “That’s beautiful.”

Then he leaned in to kiss her, a testament to their shared moment together. As he approached, he wondered if the significance of this light peck would be to express a platonic appreciation, a generalized feeling of having loved and been loved, or whether it was mere attraction to the person whose profile floated in the reddish waves. Taking in a shaky breath, he closed his eyes and braced his mouth for the glorious slap of satisfaction that accompanied the taste of her lips.

Heather blinked as Del’s face neared hers, as though she had only just remembered that he stood there beside her. She glanced at the water—a splash of blue—or the sand—a gentle brush—or the sky—a sea of blank space holding

together this delicately balanced world—and found nothing to distract her gaze. Her teeth were trapped in the realization that something had to be done or said. Her eyes focused on Del's shifting weight and tilted face as he drew nearer.

Before his lips could reach hers, Heather burst into peals of laughter. At first, it seemed like a prelude to a warning, a gesture that she could stand and leave him there alone on the shore to wallow in his misguided affection. However, she managed to laugh louder and louder until her laughter transformed into an embrace of the sun's atmosphere. It mocked the tiny flecks of sand that had bitten her feet for the past nineteen days and yet spread a joyful contagion that consumed the pair.

Surprised by her reaction, Del pulled back at once. Her head melted back into her flip-flopped shoulders, and her joy seemed genuine and resounding. Del's surprise turned to heightened uncertainty, his footing unstable like the sand beneath his feet.

Giggling, Heather glanced at Del. "Sorry, I was just thinking about...this one beach trip I had with my family. There was this jellyfish," she said, nostalgia filling her eyes as she looked back on the memory. A tear pressed itself against the bottom of her eye. Del innately understood that while others cried when they were sad, Heather cried most sincerely when she was happy. Heady memories could draw a tear from even the most resilient heart. Studying the changes in her expression, he realized the transition away from his kiss displayed their turbulent emotions. He shuffled closer to the waterline, feeling foolish and thinking that his initial gesture had been clumsy and thoughtless, even rude. He understood that he had been caught up in the reds and oranges and blues and purples of the breaking surf on the line of the horizon, fixating on the place where the water drifted back out to sea to join the infinity.

Reassessing their situation, Del grasped Heather's hand and led her further down the wet shoreline. The sand provided a massaging resistance against their heels and toes, evoking a sensation of vulnerability and closeness with every step.

Del tried to take control of his daydreams. He placed a wager against himself about the idea of diving past the sea-streaks of red-purple heavens and plunging into the sweet ache of burning pleasure that light-burn caused behind his peeled eyelids. The cold seagrass would attempt to wrap around his legs like a sea creature, hungry for attention, persistently gnawing and nibbling its way beneath him. Del smirked at the idea of a slight tinge of burning pee that no one would ever know was there except him.

"I did always want one of those fish as a pet," Del finally answered, breaking his own thoughts.

Although he had said that, he knew he didn't actually want one—it was merely a measure of whimsy masquerading as a deep desire. Primarily, through the act of confessing their desires, what Del wanted was to settle the mood and absorb

the tidal wave of her giggling. He knew he would admit to anything, within reason, just to enshrine that moment and preserve it as a shared memory.

Dashing her laughter against the sand, Heather replied, "I think that's not safe," her voice layered in amusement.

As they continued their seaside exploration, it seemed as though a whole tanker of oil had been spilled on the water, the surface slick and shiny and roiling. The wind whistled around broken shell fragments and brushed against their knees, stirring up the sand beneath their toes as it moved with purpose.

As they walked, Del straightened his frame, and for a moment, he was no longer concerned with the sea, the setting sun, the depth of oil slick, and the million invasive species that swam just below. Instead, his thoughts shifted to the trembling of his thighs and how best to muffle the whimpering whine that haunted their final night together.

Regardless, the night was young, and their nerves could be chased away with the rise of the moon. Heather looked at the approaching tide, her chest swallowing another laughter-induced gasp. The water seemed to wade closer in an attempt to absorb the last of the blues and the oranges and the purples and the reds into a wild dance of harmony and discord at the same time. And that sense of unease wrapped snugly around them, two people with their hearts trapped in dreams of what could have been.

In the twilight, Del offered a weak smile. Beachside, with the night young and Heather's chest filled with an innocuous laugh, he felt a renewed sense of hope. Time never seemed to move more slowly than when it kept pace with Heather's thoughts, all woven and adorned with the very shades of fascination that clung to their seaside forms.

Before the sun could completely disappear beneath the waves and merge with the water, Heather swallowed the last rays of light and turned towards Del, their gazes meeting in a crescendo of possibility. They traveled onwards, lost in the fleeting beauty of that final beach day. A gentle breeze tugged at their sun-kissed skin as they strolled along their own private world, allowing their laughter and unspoken words to create a beautiful symphony.

And there, amidst the vanishing light and the melding of colors, Heather and Del continued to build memories, existing together in an intricate balance between wanting and fearing. Their hearts pulsed to the rhythm of the tide, leaving behind a love story etched in both the shifting sands and the transient waves, forever a testament to the mosaic of emotions they crafted together as one.

-----The End-----

Story3

Sarah and Max stood on the shoreline, their hands still entwined. They were filled with a mix of excitement and sadness as they watched the waves crash

against the sandy beach. The long-awaited beach trip had finally come, but it also served as a farewell before the culmination of their residency.

For months, they had been residents of this idyllic town, spending their days creating art and their nights weaving a connection that defied easy definition. They had grown closer, becoming more than just friends, but they both knew that their time in this town was drawing to an end.

As they strolled along the shore, the sun began its gentle descent, casting a mesmerizing golden glow across the vast expanse. The crashing waves matched the subtle tensions that had started to weave their way between Sarah and Max.

Abruptly, Sarah halted, her gaze fixated on the distant horizon. Max turned towards her, his face perplexed with curiosity. She nervously tucked a stray strand of hair behind her ear and avoided meeting his gaze. "Max, there's something we need to discuss," she murmured, her voice barely audible over the rhythmic waves.

His heart sank at the solemnity in her tone, but he silently nodded, urging her to continue. They settled onto a cozy patch of sand, just out of reach of the encroaching tide. It became a small refuge amidst the vastness of the beach.

Taking a deep breath, Sarah gathered her thoughts, searching for the right words to express the swirling turmoil within her. "We've been avoiding the inevitable, Max," she finally said, her voice tinged with traces of sadness. "During our time here, we've grown closer, and now that it's almost over, we can't just pretend like it never happened."

Max's eyes softened, his hand gently reaching for hers. "I understand, Sarah," he whispered, his voice filled with a mixture of comprehension and sorrow. "But how do we move forward? How do we navigate this complexity without unraveling everything we've built?"

Sarah leaned into his touch, finding solace in the warmth exchanged between their palms. "Maybe it doesn't have to be wholly defined, Max," she murmured. "Perhaps it's enough to acknowledge what we feel, to cherish these moments we've shared without putting unnecessary labels on it."

Max nodded, a flicker of hope shimmering in his eyes. "I can do that, Sarah," he replied softly. "As long as we're on the same page, as long as we understand that this is a space we've carved out for ourselves, separate from the rest of our lives."

The sun dipped below the horizon, and the sky turned into a canvas adorned with vibrant hues. They sat in silence, allowing their unspoken desires to mingle with the salty breeze. In these stolen moments, away from the scrutiny of the outside world, Sarah and Max found solace.

Their conversation was interrupted by the arrival of a stray dog. Its wet nose nudged against their hands, seeking their attention. It became a small moment of levity, a reminder that life often unfolded in unpredictable and incomplete

ways. They laughed and played with the dog, its wagging tail bridging the complexities of their emotions and the simplicity of the present moment.

As the night deepened, and the stars sprinkled across the sky, they made their way back to the residency. Every step they took was slow and deliberate, their hands occasionally brushing against each other, but the weight of their imminent departures loomed between them.

In the days that followed, time seemed to slip through their fingers like the sand on the beach. Sarah found solace in her art, pouring her emotions into each brushstroke, while Max immersed himself in the solitude of his studio, weaving his experiences into the very fabric of his creations.

Finally, the day of their departure arrived. Tear-filled farewells were exchanged, along with promises to stay in touch. With heavy hearts, Sarah and Max bid the residency town adieu and boarded separate flights to their respective homes.

Months passed, filled with missed calls and unanswered messages. Life's demands had reclaimed their attention, and the ephemeral relationship they had built on that beach seemed like a distant memory. Yet, in the quiet moments of the night, Sarah and Max found themselves inexplicably drawn back to that special place, their hearts forever tethered by the bonds they had shared.

And then, one day, fate intervened. Max received a call from an art gallery in a neighboring city, requesting a meeting. Hesitant but filled with a renewed sense of hope, Max agreed, compelled by a longing he could no longer suppress.

The door to the gallery swung open, and Max's eyes locked with familiar ones. Standing before him was Sarah, a delightful mix of surprise and joy etched across her face. In that glorious moment, all unspoken desires and lingering tensions dissipated.

They embraced each other, a reunion born from the complexities they had once navigated together. Sarah's hand found its place in Max's, threads of connection once again intertwined. No longer ephemeral, their relationship had fortified itself, shaped by the unspoken and the unforeseen.

As they stood in that gallery, yearning blending with opportunity, Sarah and Max knew that their beach trip had marked not an end, but a beginning. The complexity of their love, now liberated from the confines of that residency, would continue to shape their lives, their art, and their shared journey into the unknown.

Months turned into years, and Sarah and Max's bond grew deeper. They moved in together, creating a haven where they could express themselves freely, both artistically and emotionally. They continued to inspire each other, their passion for art and for each other fuelling their creative endeavors.

Their art was exhibited in galleries around the world, and collectors eagerly sought out their unique pieces. Yet, despite their success, their hearts remained

grounded in the simplicity of that beach trip, where they had first acknowledged their connection.

Every summer, they returned to that idyllic town, the place that had witnessed the birth of their love. They would stroll along the familiar shoreline, hand in hand, reminiscing about the beginning of their journey.

They would pause at the spot where they had once sat, having that heart-to-heart conversation. It had been a turning point, a moment of vulnerability and honesty that had set the stage for their enduring love story.

As the waves gently caressed the shore, Sarah and Max would silently reflect on how far they had come. Their lives had taken unexpected twists and turns, but through it all, they had never lost sight of the love they had forged in that special place.

And as they continued their walk, their hearts filled with gratitude for the beach that had brought them together and the depth of their connection that had held them steady through the years. Their love story, born from the complexities of an artist's residency, had blossomed into something extraordinary, and it would continue to evolve and flourish with each passing day.

Years rolled by, their love matured like fine wine, and they found themselves at the pinnacle of their careers. Sarah's art was known for its emotional depth and raw vulnerability, while Max's creations spoke volumes through their intricate details and subtle symbolism.

Their works received critical acclaim, and art enthusiasts from all corners of the world flocked to their exhibitions. Despite their professional success, their hearts remained rooted in their love for each other and the transformative power it had on their art.

One summer, they received an invitation to showcase their work at a prestigious international art festival. The opportunity was too remarkable to decline, and they eagerly prepared for the journey ahead. On their way to the festival, they stopped at their beloved beach town, once again finding solace in the familiar sights and sounds.

As they walked hand in hand along the shoreline, memories of their early days flooded their minds. They remembered the innocent laughter, the stolen kisses, and the countless conversations that had shaped their relationship. It felt surreal to revisit those moments, like stepping into a time capsule that preserved their love throughout the years.

The festival was a whirlwind of emotions and connections. Sarah and Max's art resonated with the audience, evoking a profound response that brought tears to many eyes. Collectors clamored to acquire their pieces, recognizing the hidden depths within each stroke and brushstroke.

But amidst the accolades and adoration, Sarah and Max never lost sight of what truly mattered. They knew that their art was an extension of their souls, and it

was their love for each other that fueled their creative spirit. No matter how far they traveled, it was always the love they nurtured on that beach that anchored them and gave their art its unique essence.

Years turned into decades, and Sarah and Max's love story continued to inspire. They became the embodiment of a lifelong artistic partnership, showcasing the power of shared dreams and unyielding support. Their love only grew stronger with time, a testament to the enduring connections that can be forged in even the most serendipitous of moments.

As they reached old age, their bodies frail and their steps slow, Sarah and Max found solace in each other's arms, just as they had on that sandy beach so many years ago. They cherished every remaining moment, knowing that their love had left an indelible mark on the world.

And when they finally closed their eyes for the last time, their hands still entwined, their spirits took flight, guided by the ethereal beauty of the love they had shared. Their souls danced together through the celestial realms, forever bonded by the irreversible magic of an artist's beach trip.

-----The End-----

Story4

The old Dodge rattled down the winding cliffside road toward the beach, its worn shocks protesting each pothole. Jane gripped the sun-cracked vinyl seat, glancing over at Mark behind the wheel. His brow was furrowed, focused on navigating the treacherous turns through the coastal fog. The radio played softly, an old jazz tune Jane vaguely recognized filling the silence between them. She felt a pang of longing for the familiar, although over the past month at the residency she had grown accustomed to the isolated quiet of her studio and sparse encounters with others at meals.

Jane thought back to the first time she had seen Mark, a month ago at the welcome dinner for the artist residency. He had been quietly confident, making wry observations about the eccentric group of creatives thrown together in communal living. His sardonic humor and reticent thoughtfulness had drawn her in immediately. However, her shyness held her back from striking up a conversation with him that night. She chided herself for her hesitance now, aware of the precious little time remaining before their inevitable parting in two days.

For weeks, they had been cloistered at the artists' residency, tucked away in the woods and working in solitude. The sprawling main house and studios sat on a hundred acres of forest, an escape from the tempo of ordinary life. Meals were the only times they regularly crossed paths. Polite greetings were exchanged, discussions of work and process, but little else. There was an unspoken charge between them, a kind of heat—at least Jane felt it in his lingering glances and the twitch of a smile he allowed himself when they made eye contact. She found excuses to linger in the communal spaces, hoping for a stolen moment or private word with Mark. Their encounters were fleeting but fueled her longing. During

one dinner, as candlelight flickered across the table, Mark asked Jane about her own work. She explained her use of dramatic colors and abstractions to convey emotion, while he nodded thoughtfully, dark eyes peering intently at her.

Jane felt the residency was ending too quickly. Over the past month, she had started and scrapped three paintings, unable to focus because of her preoccupation with Mark. Her thoughts kept drifting to his dark eyes, his deliberate way of considering a question before answering, the glimpses of humor he allowed to surface when recounting some absurdist tale of life in the city. She felt anchored to him by invisible threads, being reeled in bit by bit with each furtive look across the mess hall. The hushed, intimate dinners they had shared, making eye contact across the worn farm table, left her breathless in a way she hadn't felt for years.

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The residency was ending in two days. This would likely be their last excursion together. Jane had suggested heading to the beach to escape the claustrophobia of the communal space, filled with the detritus of temporary inhabitants about to disperse. Mark had agreed with uncharacteristic eagerness that surprised and delighted her. After a month of quick, awkward encounters, his sudden enthusiasm gave her a burst of hope that had been absent before.

The Dodge emerged from the woods into a sandy clearing. The fog parted to reveal the wide blue ocean stretched endlessly before them, azure waters lapping at ivory sands. Mark pulled the car up to the shore and cut the engine. They set up their towels and umbrella in silence, the anxious energy between them palpable. Jane felt self-conscious in her swimsuit under Mark's appreciative gaze and busied herself arranging their provisions, fighting the urge to cover up. She walked down to the soothing sound of waves lapping at the shore. The beach stretched before Jane, a pale curve of sand giving way to emerald swells.

Jane slipped off her sundress, acutely aware of Mark's appreciative gaze on her as she did so, and walked toward the surf in her swimsuit. The chilled water was bracing, raising goosebumps on her bare skin. She dove under the next wave breaking, cool water washing the heat and tension from her body. Surfacing with a gasp, Jane began to find a steady rhythm in the sea. The saltwater cleared her mind, but also heightened her senses, aware of Mark waiting for her on the beach. She drifted between fantasies of what was still possible between them to agonizing over the missed opportunities and their imminent separation. Everything seemed dreamlike and hazy in the fog, as if this moment might

dissolve into the ether at any moment.

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When she returned to their encampment, Mark was reading under the umbrella. His shy smile and lingering embrace as he wrapped her in a towel and handed her a thermos of coffee gave her hope that this day might lead to new beginnings for them. They sat together under the banner of shade for hours, gazing out at the sea, conversing more freely than ever before. Jane opened up extensively about her work, her past, her family, and her hopes while Mark listened intently, drawing out more details with his astute questions. She was surprised by their easy rapport, how fully she felt seen and how at ease she felt opening up to Mark. He recounted amusing anecdotes from past relationships, travel misadventures, eccentric neighbors and life in the city. His wry observations and witty stories kept her spellbound throughout the long, golden afternoon.

As the sun began to set, they realized with disappointment that they would have to head back soon to the residency. Jane suggested a walk along the shore to stretch their legs and make the most of their remaining time together. Hand in hand they meandered down the winding coastline, waves gently lapping at their feet. An easy intimacy developed between them as they wandered together, talking for hours it seemed. The sea and sky were awash in orange and pink, as if the world itself was aflame.

They returned to the old Dodge as night fell, damp sand clinging to their bare feet. Jane felt both buoyant at the deep connection formed with Mark today and bereft at its impermanence. The drive back to the residency was quiet but comfortable, no words needed. At the main house, they lingered in a tender embrace. Jane tilted her face up to Mark's, finding his lips in a long, slow kiss. They clung to one another, both wanting more yet aware their time was up. With reluctance, Mark bid her goodnight and they parted, unsure of what tomorrow would bring but grateful for the gift of today.

-----The End-----